

SENATE BILL 2156

By Haile

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,
relative to educators.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 5, is amended by adding the following as a new part:

49-5-1201. Short title.

This part is known and may be cited as the "Tennessee Teacher Residency Program Act."

49-5-1202. Part definitions.

As used in this part:

- (1) "Department" means the department of education;
- (2) "Educator preparation provider" or "EPP" means an educator preparation provider approved by the state board of education;
- (3) "Partnering LEA" means an LEA or public charter school formally partnering with an EPP or nonprofit education preparation provider to operate a residency program;
- (4) "Residency program" means an education-related organization or 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization that conducts teacher preparation training using a residency model in partnership with an LEA, institute of higher education, or EPP;
- (5) "State board" means the state board of education; and
- (6) "Teacher resident" means an aspiring educator who is participating in a residency program to complete requirements for an initial educator license.

49-5-1203. Tennessee teacher residency program established – Administration.

(a) The department shall establish and implement a program to support residency programs by awarding grants to residency programs pursuant to this part.

(b) To be eligible to receive a grant awarded pursuant to this section, a residency program must meet the requirements in this part and in rules promulgated by the state board.

(c) Subject to appropriations, the department shall award no more than forty-four thousand five hundred dollars (\$44,500) per teacher resident participating in a residency program to support program operating costs, resident stipends, and mentor teacher stipends for up to one hundred (100) teacher residents in an academic year.

(d) Partnering LEAs shall collaborate with EPPs or educator-related organizations to facilitate the employment of teacher residents upon completion of the residency program and obtaining an educator license.

49-5-1204. Residency program design and components.

In order to be eligible to receive a grant pursuant to § 49-5-1203, a residency program must:

(1) Be designed to enrich the teaching profession and ensure teacher residents are prepared for educator licensure;

(2) Require a teacher resident to complete at least one (1) full academic year of rigorous EPP coursework integrated with a concurrent full academic year of guided clinical apprenticeship in a partnering LEA classroom under the supervision of a mentor teacher;

(3) Utilize competitive admission requirements for teacher residents;

(4) Use clear criteria based on effectiveness for selecting mentor teachers;

- (5) Provide evidence-based training and compensation to mentor teachers;
- (6) Group teacher residents in cohorts for professional collaboration, when practicable;
- (7) Identify measures to determine a teacher resident's progress;
- (8) Include an expectation of employment for a teacher resident from the partnering LEA or a high-need LEA approved by the department, contingent on program completion, obtaining an educator license, and position availability;
- (9) Require teacher residents to commit to teach for a minimum of three (3) consecutive years in a public school, or public charter school, within the partnering LEA or a high-need LEA approved by the department, after program completion and obtaining an educator license. If a teacher resident fails to complete the three-year service requirement in this subdivision (9), then the residency program shall reimburse the stipend received for the teacher resident, under terms and conditions established by the department; and
- (10) Provide support for teacher residents who complete the program for at least one (1) year post-completion.

49-5-1205. Relation to licensure requirements.

A teacher resident who successfully completes a residency program that meets the requirements in § 49-5-1204 satisfies the clinical experience required in § 49-5-5604.

49-5-1206. State board of education rules.

The state board, in consultation with the department, shall promulgate rules necessary to implement this part. The rules must be promulgated in accordance with the Uniform Administrative Procedures Act, compiled in title 4, chapter 5.

49-5-1207. Reporting requirements.

(a) Residency programs that receive a grant pursuant to this part shall annually submit data to review the program's success to the department. The department shall notify each residency program of the data that must be submitted pursuant to this subsection (a) and the date by which the data must be submitted.

(b) Beginning November 1, 2028, and once every two (2) years thereafter, the department shall submit a teacher residency program report on the outcomes of residency programs participating in this program by utilizing the data received pursuant to subsection (a) to the education committee of the senate; the finance, ways and means committee of the senate; the committee of the house of representatives having jurisdiction over teachers; the committee of the house of representatives having jurisdiction over financing programs for teachers; and the state board.

SECTION 2. The headings in this act are for reference purposes only and do not constitute a part of the law enacted by this act. However, the Tennessee Code Commission is requested to include the headings in any compilation or publication containing this act.

SECTION 3. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it.